Food Access in North Carolina

Mili Shah

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Your written report goes here!

> **!** Important
>
> Before you submit, make sure your code chunks are turned off with `echo: false` and there are no warnings or messages with `warning: false` and `message: false` in the YAML.

Introduction

There are 18.8 million Americans living in food deserts today — areas with limited access to affordable and nutritious food. The USDA has defined food deserts to be census tracts that have a poverty rate of 20% or greater (or median family income that is less than 80% of statewide family income) and where at least 33% of the population (or at least 500 people) live more than 1 mile from the supermarket in an urban area/ 10 miles in a rural area. Food deserts are created not only due to distance from healthy food sources but also due to structural decisions that have historically limited healthy food access for minority communities. Understanding this issue requires examining how redlining policies institutionalized neighborhood disinvestment, disproportionately exposing low-income and minority communities to less healthy food environments. These disparities carry serious consequences: food deserts are linked to worse health outcomes, including shorter life expectancy and a higher risk for adverse cardiovascular events. Given these health risks and the disproportionate racial impact of food deserts, it is critical to evaluate what factors contribute to their persistence and how current policy can work toward reversing years of racial residential segregation.

This issue is particularly relevant to us as Duke students, as 9 of the top 10 states with the greatest share of residents living in food deserts are in the South. This proximity makes understanding the structural drivers of food deserts a matter of community concern. Thus, I seek to answer the following question: in what ways do the poverty rate of a census tract, the number of households receiving SNAP benefits, the number of households without a vehicle,

median family income, and urban/rural classification influence whether a census tract is a food desert (classified as a low-income, low-access area) in North Carolina? I will use the USDA's 2019 Food Research Atlas dataset to investigate this question and illuminate patterns in food access in North Carolina

Since this dataset is substantially large with more than 72,000 observations, fitting a model on the data could result in some predictors with extremely low p values, indicating significant impacts on the response variable, though it may not truly be the case. In order to address this limitation, I will focus specifically on North Carolina to make this analysis more relevant to our positioning as residents of the state. Though filtering the data addresses the issue of having too many observations skew the p-values, observations in the dataset could be dependent due to the fact that neighboring census tracts will likely have similar measures for variables in the dataset. To account for this, I will take a random sample of 20% of the filtered, North Carolina-specific dataset. Finally, there is substantial missing data in variables that track specific numbers, like amount of people living in a low access, low income area (`LALOWI1_10`). Thus, I will use the `LILATracts_1AND10` response variable, which is an indicator variable of what `LALOWI1_10` measures. Beyond that, if some variables have only a few missing values, I will delete those observations from the data. Therefore, I also acknowledge that this data may not be entirely representative of the entire state, especially if those null values were concentrated in a specific area. Finally, in working with health and social science data, I am also cognizant of confounding being a limitation. This dataset does not provide a comprehensive account of all the factors that impact whether a census tract is a food desert since other variables can influence this measure/ the measure of other predictors. For instance, the `TractHUNV` predictor measures the number of housing units without a vehicle in a certain tract. Though the absence of a vehicle can make healthy food inaccessible, and therefore contribute to the categorization of an area as a food desert, the variable does not give a complete picture of accessibility — especially since access to public transportation is not considered. I will remain mindful of these limitations and incorporate them into my analysis to ensure that my interpretations and conclusions are statistically sound.

Exploratory Data Analysis

Data description

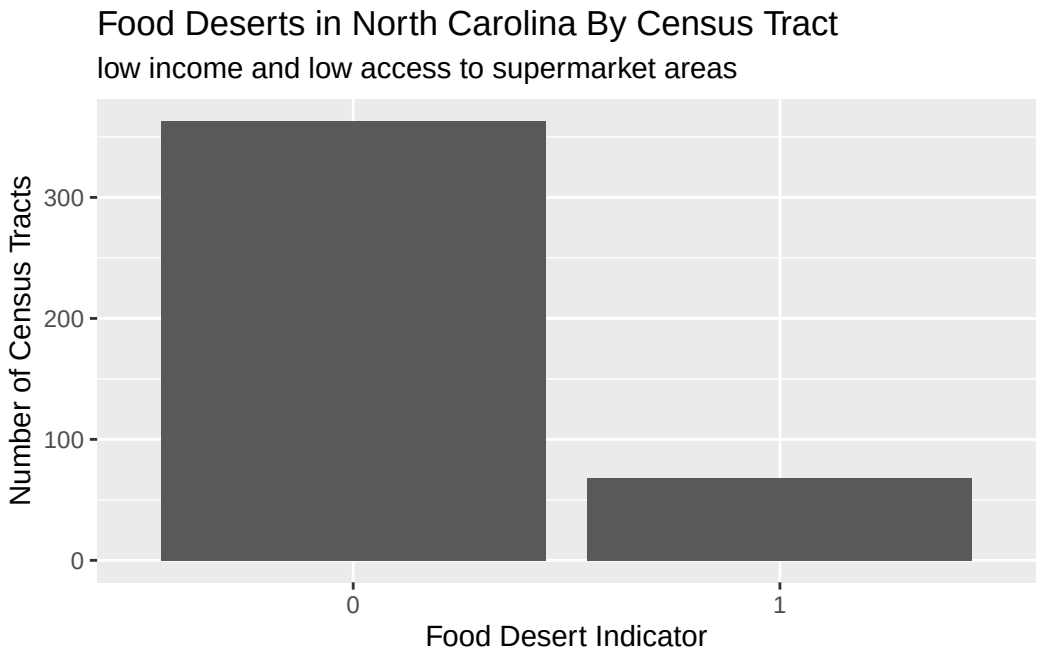
I will analyze the 2019 Food Access Research Atlas dataset from the USDA Economic Research Service. It provides an overview of food access indicators in the US by measuring variables like supermarket accessibility, race, poverty rate, and median income by census tract. This dataset is a combination of data collected by the 2010 Decennial Census, the 2014-18 American Community Survey (ACS), and two 2019 lists of supermarkets, one being from Trade Dimensions TDLinx. The 2010 Census provided population data relating to age, race, income, and poverty rate. The 2014-18 ACS contributed information about income, vehicle availability, and SNAP participation. Finally, two lists of grocery stores were combined to produce a list of stores that

have nutritious and affordable food. This data was then used to compute the variables that communicate the distance that one lives from a grocery store.

Key Variables

Each observation in the data represents an individual census tract in a specific county and state, uniquely identified by the `CensusTract` variable. In understanding factors that contribute to a census tract's categorization as low-income and low-access (or being a food desert), I will focus on the `LILATracts_1And10` response variable and the following predictor variables: `Urban` , `TractSNAP` , `TractHUNV` , `PovertyRate` , `MedianFamilyIncome` . `Urban` is an indicator variable that classifies a census tract as urban or not using the official definition by the US Census (urban area has more than 2,500 people). This predictor will contribute to understanding whether food deserts vary by urbanicity, which is helpful in understanding where policymakers should direct resources to address such issues. Next, `TractSNAP` will detail the number of people within a census tract receiving SNAP benefits. The rationale behind including this predictor is that communities with more individuals receiving SNAP benefits are also likely to be underresourced, characteristic of food deserts. `TractHUNV` provides information on access to a vehicle, which could illuminate the low access to grocery stores aspect of the food desert definition. Finally, `MedianFamilyIncome` and `Urban` will both be used to determine the general economic state of families in a census tract. Since having these two variables could present issues of multicollinearity in the model, I will check the variance inflation factor to make a decision on keeping the predictors and which one. Finally, `LILATracts_1And10` is an indicator variable which tracks if a census tract is low income and low access, measured at 1 mile for urban areas and 10 miles for rural areas. This fits the USDA's definiton of a food desert, so `LILATracts_1And10` will also serve as an abstraction for whether a census tract is classified as a food desert.

Univariate EDA

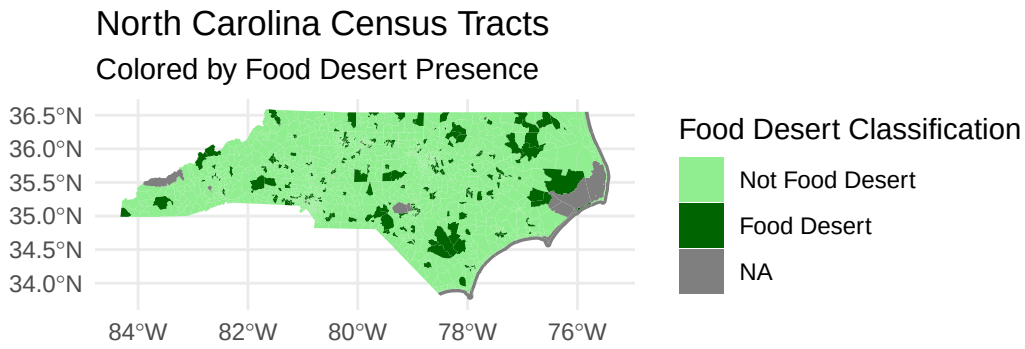



```
# A tibble: 2 x 3
  LILATracts_1And10     n  prop
  <fct>             <int> <dbl>
1 0                   363 0.842
2 1                    68 0.158
```

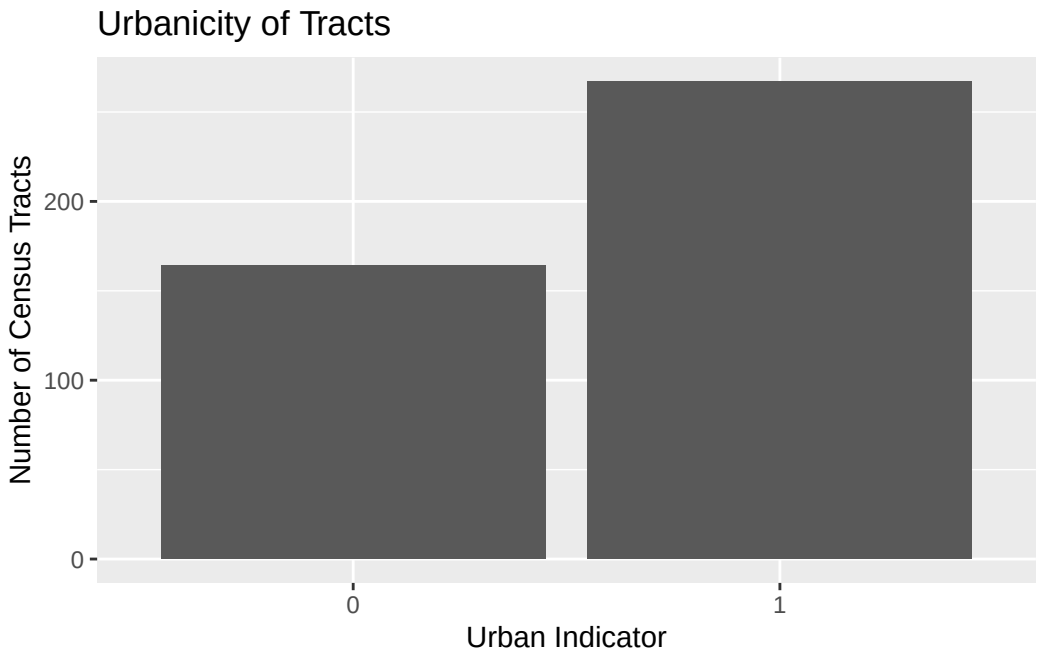
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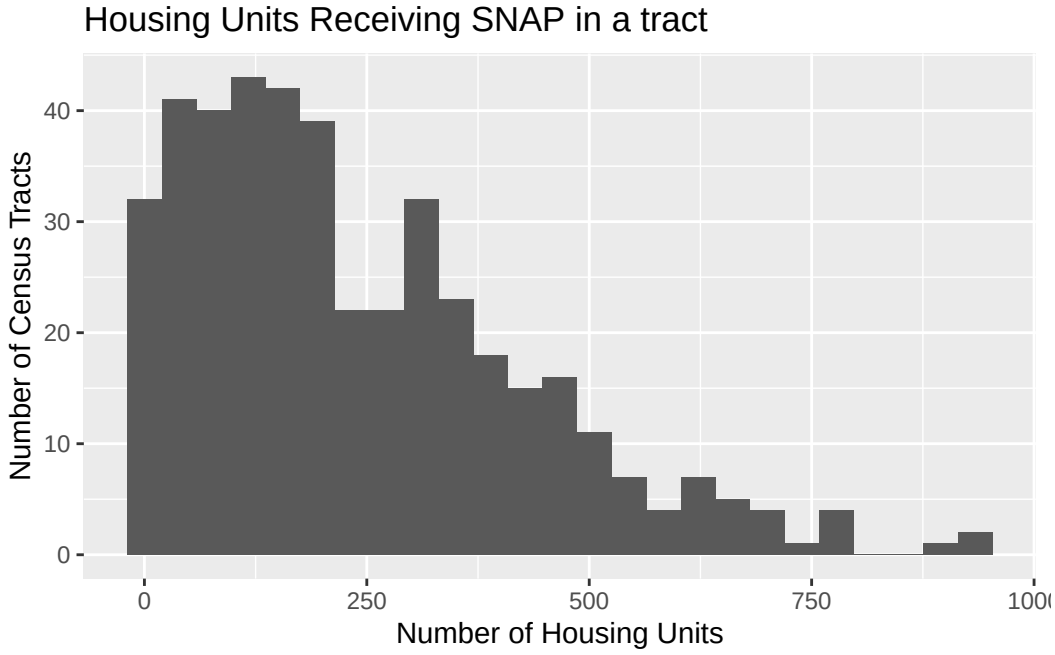
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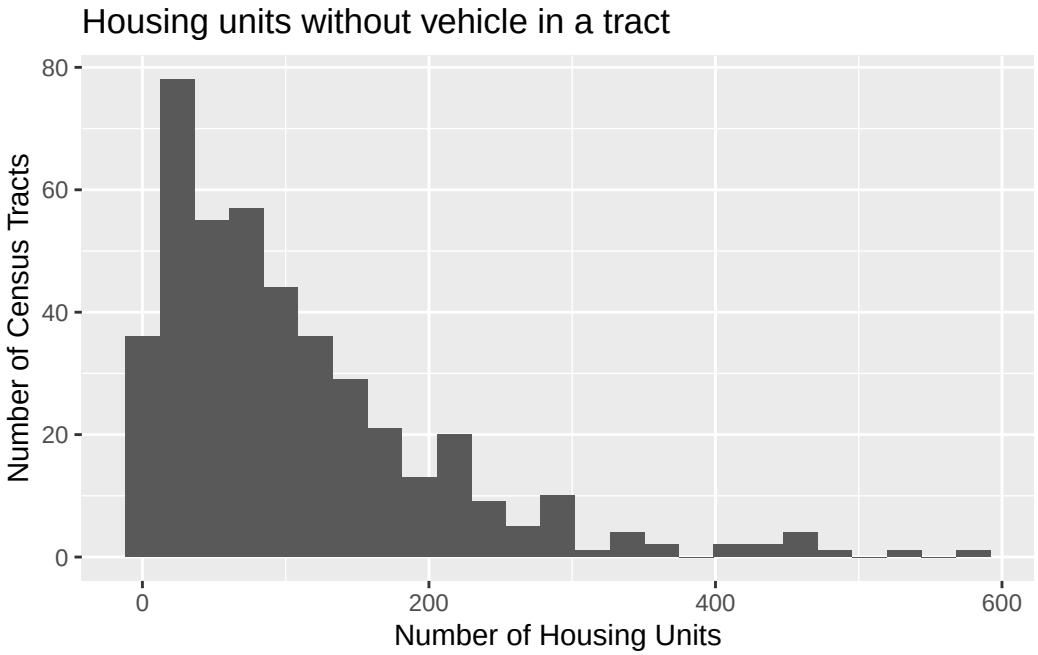
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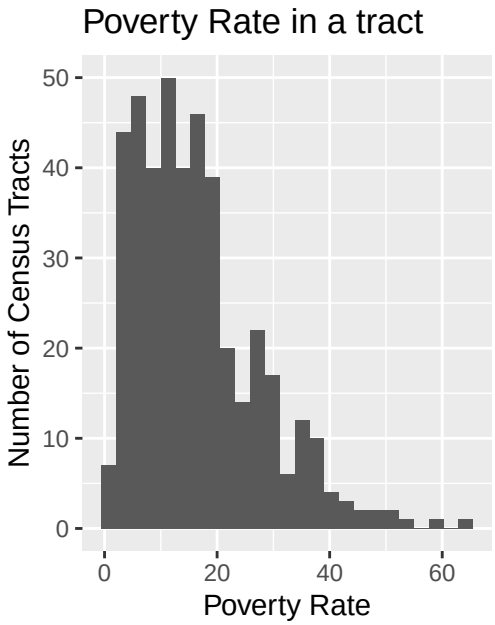


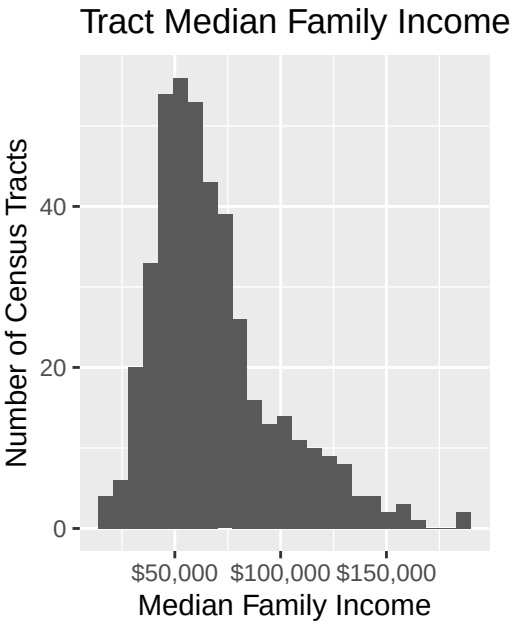
Observing the bar chart and the table about the proportion of tracts within the sample categorized as food deserts illuminates how the majority of census tracts in North Carolina (around 84%) are not food deserts. Furthermore, the map of food deserts across the state shows how food deserts are concentrated in small areas and do not simply exist at the census tract level. Noticing this is important for understanding how food deserts may not be very common, but they are evident and harmful for numerous communities across North Carolina. Finally, since `LILATracts_1And10` is mostly 0s, this suggests that the model may not predict tracts that are food deserts as well as it is able to predict tracts that are not food deserts, simply due to the amount of data it has for training. During inference, I will revisit this concern once more and consider using metrics like cross-validation to observe model performance on unseen data.


Urbanicity of Tracts
Number of Census Tracts
200
100
0
0
1
Urban Indicator


Housing Units Receiving SNAP in a tract
Number of Census Tracts
40
30
20
10
0
0
250
500
750
Number of Housing Units








```
 PovertyRate       TractSNAP        TractHUNV     MedianFamilyIncome
Min.   : 0.70   Min.   :  0.0   Min.   :  0.0   Min.   : 17404
1st Qu.: 8.25   1st Qu.: 92.5   1st Qu.: 34.0   1st Qu.: 48536
```

```
 Median :14.30   Median :188.0   Median : 80.0   Median : 61579
 Mean   :16.35   Mean   :238.3   Mean   :106.2   Mean   : 68547
 3rd Qu.:21.25   3rd Qu.:347.5   3rd Qu.:145.0   3rd Qu.: 81984
 Max.   :64.20   Max.   :934.0   Max.   :580.0   Max.   :186310
```

```
# A tibble: 2 x 3
  Urban     n  prop
  <fct> <int> <dbl>
1 0       164 0.381
2 1       267 0.619
```

The univariate EDA for predictors shows how each of the numerical predictors (`PovertyRate`, `TractSNAP`, `TractHUNV`, `MedianFamilyIncome`) have a unimodal, right-skewed distribution. `Urban` shows a similar pattern of positive skew as the majority of census tracts in North Carolina (around 62%) are classified as urban. Due to this skew, the median is a good indicator of the center of the distribution for each of the variables. Thus, we see that the median poverty rate in NC is about 14.30%, which is higher than the United States' official 10.6% poverty rate. The spread of this distribution is also substantially wide in context as the IQR is 13. There are also some outlying census tracts with poverty rates above 50%.

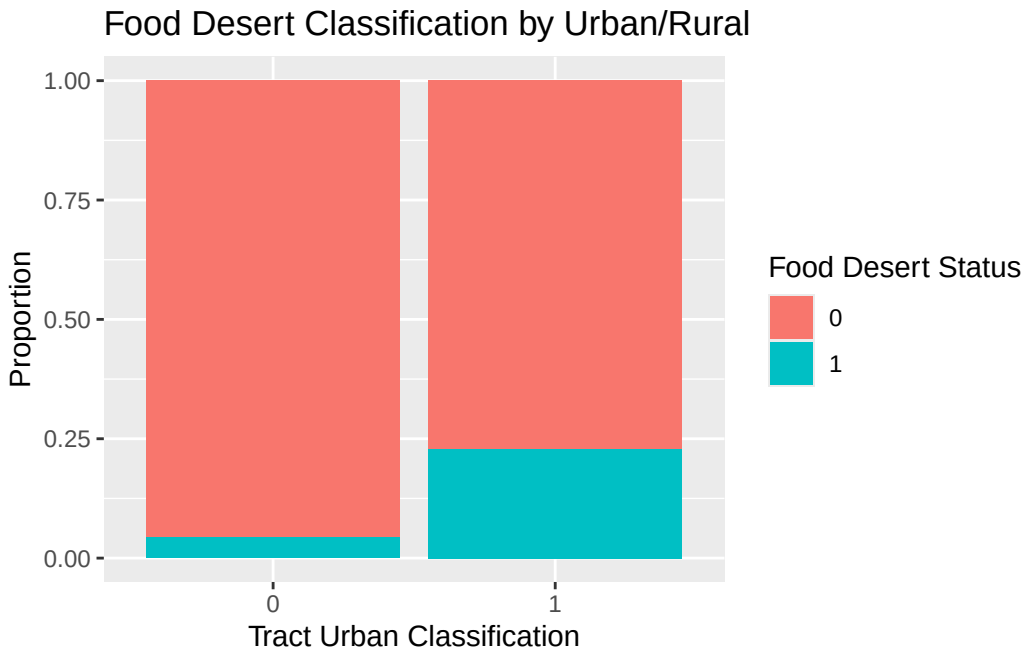
The distribution for `TractSNAP` shows a center around 188, meaning 188 housing units in a census tract receive SNAP benefits. The IQR of 255 housing units also seems relatively large, but when considering the fact that a census tract can range anywhere from 1,200 people to 8,000, this spread seems understandable due to population dynamics and urban/rural distributions. TractSNAP also has outliers at census tracts with more than 400 housing units receiving SNAP benefits.

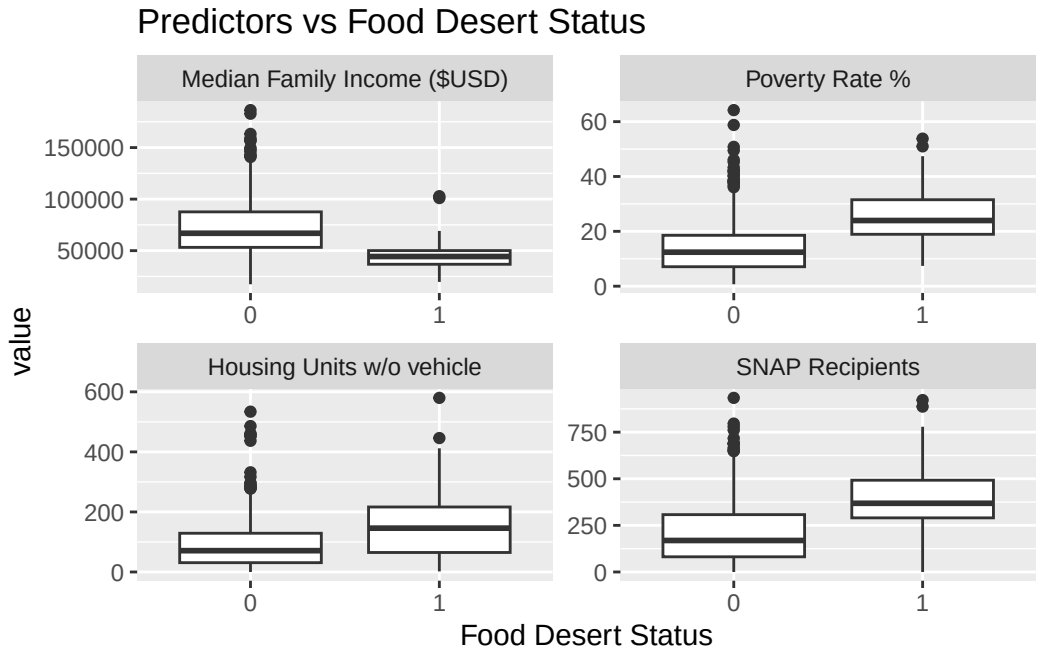
`TractHUNV` has a center of around 80 housing units in a census tract without access to a vehicle. This is surprisingly low but realistic since a car is a necessity in most parts of NC due to the state's lack of public transportation infrastructure. Similar to before, there are a few outliers observed above 400 housing units in a tract without access to a vehicle. The relatively smaller spread (IQR=11) is in line with our understanding of NC's public infrastructure and the necessity of a vehicle, regardless of income status.

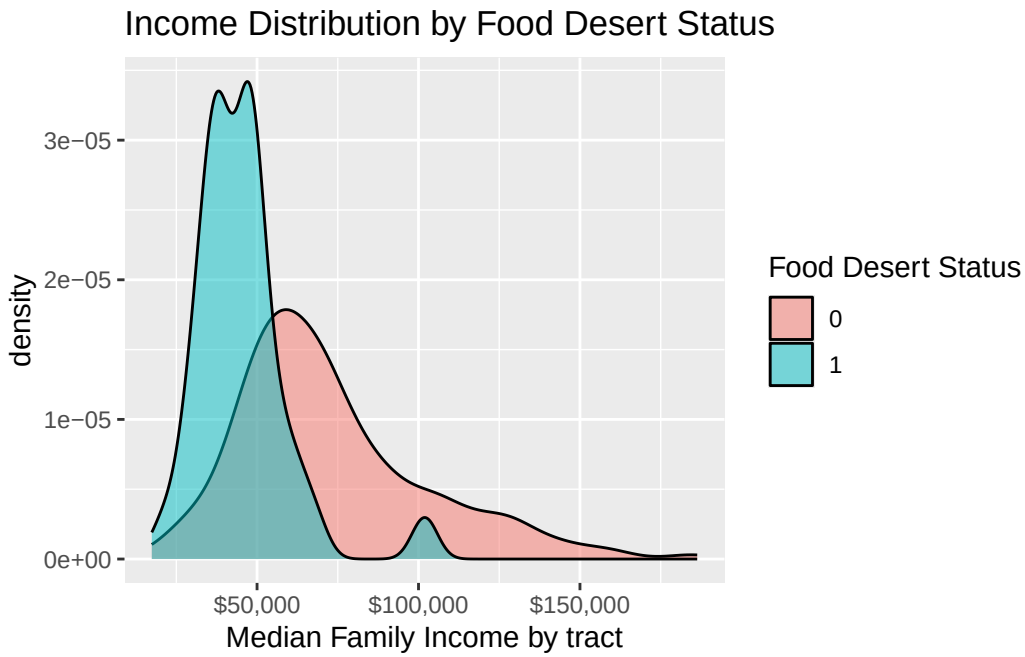
Finally, `MedianFamilyIncome` has a distribution very similar to `PovertyRate` , which is not unexpected since both are roughly measuring the economics state of a census tract. There is a center around $61,500 median family income per census tract, much lower than the US's$83,000 median household income. The spread of the distribution (IQR) is about $20,000, with outliers above median family incomes of $150,000.

Since each of these exhibits a substantial right skew and a couple of outliers, I will use metrics like Cook's distance to decide if points are influential and are harming the model's predictive capabilities. Furthermore, I will check whether these predictors need to be log transformed to represent a nonlinear relationship and account for the skew by comparing the adjusted R^2 of models with different predictors transformed.

Bivariate EDA





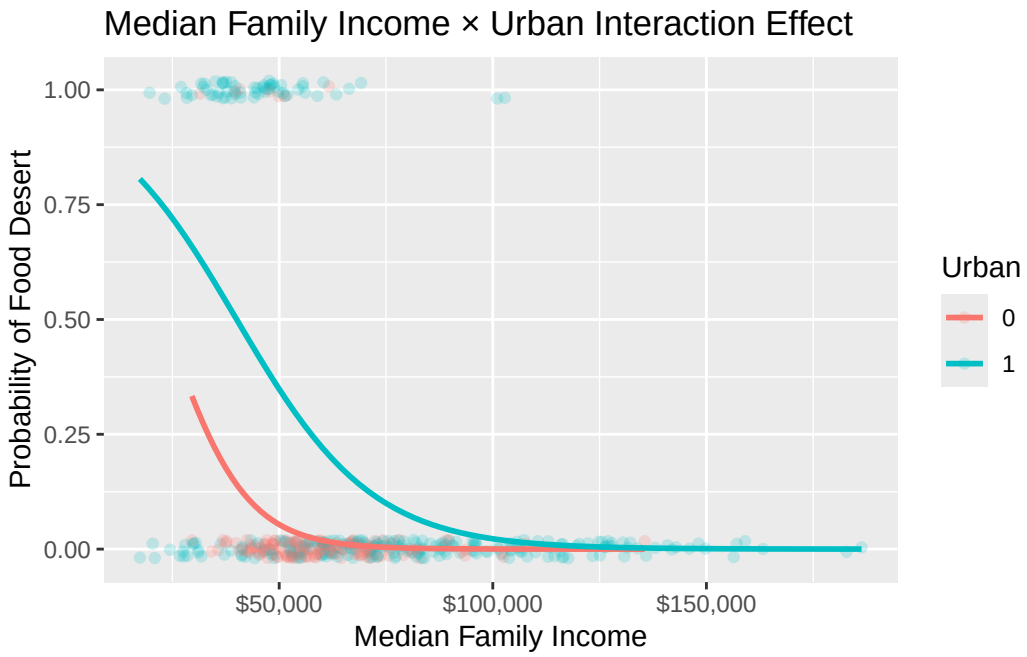


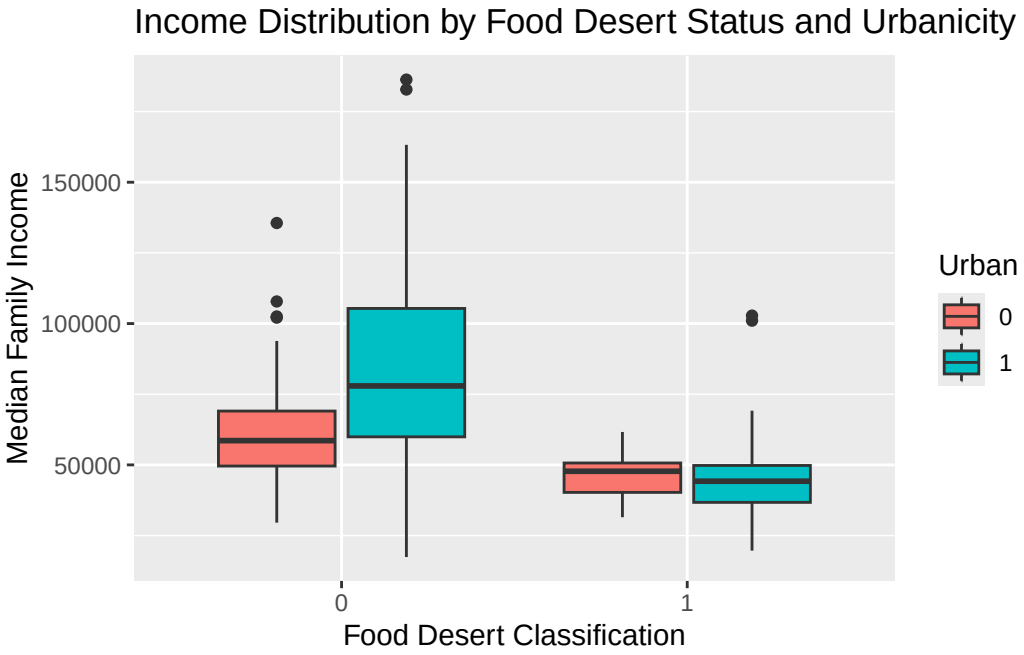
The first plot illuminates an interesting pattern that a higher proportion of urban tracts are food deserts rather than rural tracts. Further analysis in the next steps of this project will investigate specific cases that may contribute to this counterintuitive pattern, as well as explain some hotspots of food deserts observed in the preliminary map. In addition to the facet plot, the double density plot of median family income differing by food desert status is an important visualization to understand how much the distribution of incomes within a tract varies according to whether the tract is in a food desert or not. For instance, tracts that are not food deserts have a similar center to tracts that are food deserts, but the median incomes are more spread out from $45,000 to $125,000, while median incomes for tracts in food deserts are mostly concentrated around $45,000 to $50,000. This pattern is important for solidifying the necessity of using median family income as a predictor for food desert status. The visualization also promotes an understanding of more routine or customary median family incomes across the state, which is important for conceptualizing the extent to which financial status impacts living conditions and location.

Finally, the facet plot shows very interesting and potentially significantly different relationships for each predictor against food desert status since the boxes of the box plots are (mostly) not contained within each other and vary vertically. This pattern is especially evident in `MedianFamilyIncome`, `TractSNAP`, and `TractHUNV`. As mentioned earlier, tracts that are not food deserts have a noticeably higher median family income, and tracts that are food deserts have both smaller median family incomes as well as smaller variance. The remainder of the predictors show similar patterns to each other, where tracts that are food deserts see a greater number of housing units without a vehicle, a greater number of households receiving SNAP, and higher poverty rates. Each of these see significant differences between their non-food-

desert-census-tract counterparts, but this significance will be reevaluated by assessing p-values of the predictors in the logistic regression model. In addition to providing motivation for using these predictors in the model, the box plots also provide a clearer view of the outliers. Across each of the faceted plots, there seem to be more outliers for tracts that are not classified as food deserts. This may be due to a wider spread of values and less uniformity in socioeconomic characteristics among non–food desert tracts. When creating our model, this knowledge can be helpful in determining other predictors to add or potential interactions with demographic characteristics present in the dataset. As a whole, this depiction of outliers also solidifies the need to assess how influential the outliers are for the model, which will determine if we will remove them for improved predictive power.

Interaction Effects





In the first plot, we see how higher levels of median family income are linked to higher probabilities of food deserts — in both the lines plotted, regardless of urban classification. However, the plot shows that an interaction between urbanicity and median family income certainly exists because the slopes for the two lines are substantially different. The plot shows that tracts classified as urban have higher probabilities of being food deserts than tracts classified as rural at the same median income. While the lines converge at median family incomes above $125,000, the initial difference serves as evidence that some of the variability between the probability of a food desert and median family income can be explained by a census tract being urban or rural. The second plot serves to reinforce this assessment. The two groups of boxes for tracts classified as food deserts and those as not are significantly different because the boxes do not overlap across groups. The interaction effect between median family income and urbanicity is especially apparent in the census tracts not classified as food deserts, as the plot shows how rural tracts in non-food deserts have a considerably lower median family income than urban tracts. Thus, rather than simply seeing how median family income varies according to food desert classification, adding urbanicity creates an additional, important interaction to consider.